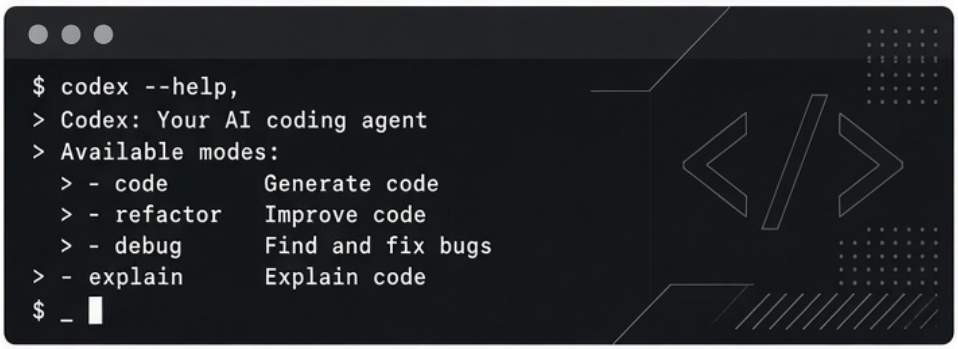
OPENAI

INTELLIGENCE × CODE × IMPACT

Codex For Dummies

Your Complete Beginner's Guide to OpenAI's Coding Agent



ER. RISHABH ARYAN

2026 EDITION

Grok

Codex
For Dummies

Your Complete Beginner's Guide to OpenAI's Coding Agent

Er. Rishabh Aryan
M.Tech (Artificial Intelligence and Data Science)
Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Indian Institute of Information Technology, Bhagalpur (Bihar)
E-mail: rishabh.250201011@iiitbh.ac.in
ORCID: 0009-0004-7595-9440

2026

Contents

Introduction — What Codex Is
Chapter 1 — Getting Started with Codex
Chapter 2 — Using the CLI and Local Agent
Chapter 3 — Cloud Tasks and Environments
Chapter 4 — Working Effectively with the Agent
Chapter 5 — Plans, Usage, and Limits
Chapter 6 — Best Practices and Safety
Appendix — Glossary and Resources

Introduction

What Codex Is

Codex is OpenAI’s coding agent. Unlike a simple chat interface where you copy and paste code, Codex can read your repository, plan changes, edit files, run commands, check results, and iterate. It is available through a command-line interface (CLI), IDE integrations, a desktop experience, and cloud tasks.

There is no separate Codex subscription. Access is included with ChatGPT plans (Free with limitations, Plus, Pro, Business, Enterprise, etc.). You can also use the open-source CLI with your own API key for usage-based billing.

REMEMBER

Codex is an agent that acts on your codebase. ChatGPT is conversational. Use Codex when the job involves reading, editing, and verifying code in a project.

Chapter 1

Getting Started with Codex

Access Codex through your ChatGPT account or install the CLI. The CLI is open source and can run locally.

1. Ensure you have a ChatGPT account (Plus or higher recommended for regular use).

2. Install the Codex CLI (follow current instructions on the official OpenAI documentation or GitHub).

3. Authenticate with your OpenAI account or API key.

4. Navigate to a project directory and start a session.

5. Describe a task in plain language and review the proposed changes.

> **TIP**
>
> Begin with a small, non-critical repository so you can learn how the agent behaves before using it on important code.

Chapter 2

Using the CLI and Local Agent

The Codex CLI runs in your terminal. It explores the project, reads relevant files (including AGENTS.md if present), proposes a plan, and executes changes under an approval policy you control.

You can set different sandbox levels: read-only for questions, workspace-write (common default) for editing inside the project and running commands, or broader access when needed. Always review diffs before accepting.

REMEMBER

The agent works in a loop: it edits, runs checks or tests when appropriate, reads the output, and corrects. Your main control is approving or rejecting steps.

Chapter 3

Cloud Tasks and Environments

Cloud tasks let Codex work on a repository in a remote sandbox. Useful for longer jobs that continue while your local machine is offline. Reusable cloud environments can pre-install dependencies so each task starts faster.

Availability and virtual machine size depend on your plan. Cloud features are generally stronger on higher tiers (Pro, Business, Enterprise). Code review agents and scheduled security-related scans are also available in some configurations.

Chapter 4

Working Effectively with the Agent

Clear task descriptions produce better results. Specify the desired behavior, relevant files or areas, and any constraints. Provide an AGENTS.md file in the repository root to document conventions, testing commands, and preferred approaches.

Review every significant change. Use the agent for feature implementation, refactoring, debugging, test writing, and code review. For very large or high-risk changes, break the work into smaller steps and verify intermediate results.

TIP

Write a short AGENTS.md that lists how to run tests, style rules, and what not to change. This context helps the agent stay consistent.

Chapter 5

Plans, Usage, and Limits

Codex usage is included with ChatGPT plans. There is no separate subscription. Higher plans provide larger allowances. Usage is typically measured in a rolling window (for example, a five-hour window) plus weekly caps, and is tracked in credits that align with model token costs.

Free and lower tiers offer limited access. Plus and above unlock fuller local and cloud capabilities. Pro tiers and Business/Enterprise provide higher or pooled usage. You can also use an API key for pure usage-based billing outside plan limits. Always check the official Codex pricing page for current numbers.

WARNING

Heavy agent use consumes credits quickly. Monitor your usage dashboard. After included limits are reached, additional work may require credits or may be restricted until the window resets.

Chapter 6

Best Practices and Safety

• Start with small tasks and expand as you trust the agent.

• Always review diffs and test results before merging.

• Use version control and commit frequently so you can revert.

• Keep secrets and credentials out of the repository and out of prompts.

• Set appropriate approval policies and sandbox levels.

• Document project conventions in AGENTS.md.

• Monitor usage so you stay within plan limits.

• Stay updated with official documentation and changelogs.

Appendix

Glossary and Resources

Codex CLI: Open-source command-line interface for running the coding agent locally.

Cloud Task: A coding job executed in a remote sandbox environment.

AGENTS.md: Optional project file that gives the agent instructions about conventions and workflows.

Sandbox: Restricted environment that controls what the agent can read, write, and execute.

Credits: Usage units that track model consumption; higher plans include more.

Resources

• OpenAI official site and Codex documentation

• ChatGPT / Codex access via chatgpt.com

• Codex CLI on GitHub (open source)

• Pricing and limits pages on openai.com

About the Author

Er. Rishabh Aryan holds an M.Tech in Artificial Intelligence and Data Science from the Department of Computer Science and Engineering at the Indian Institute of Information Technology, Bhagalpur (Bihar). Contact: rishabh.250201011@iiitbh.ac.in. ORCID: 0009-0004-7595-9440.

This is an independent educational guide. Codex features, models, limits, and pricing change. Always consult official OpenAI documentation for the most current information.